



The New Threat Landscape, Powered by AI & Social Engineering

Notes from Session 1 of 3, part of the CLC: 2026 Certified AI Email Security Specialist learning path: written up so the hour doesn't have to be replayed to remember it.

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QUICK RECALL

Grammar is no longer a reliable tell; LLMs write flawlessly. Legacy MFA is losing to AiTM proxies. RMM tools (ScreenConnect especially) are now attackers' go-to first payload.

01 · INTRODUCTION

The role of AI in the threat landscape

Everything attackers do with AI falls into two buckets: sharper social engineering, or more capable offensive tooling.

BROADLY, "SOCIAL ENGINEERING"

Language assistance

Language translation, content creation

Impersonation

Voice and video deepfakes, realistic chat

BROADLY, "OFFENSIVE AI"

Code development

Website creation, malware development

Automated command & control

Dynamic, real-time infrastructure change;
adaptive attacks

"Smart" brute force

Mass-scale password-spraying, dictionary
cycling

02 · WHY THE OLD TELLS STOPPED WORKING

"The Death of the Nigerian Prince": social engineering is better than ever

AI lets attackers shift language, dialect, and audience with a simple prompt, drawing on scraped social media and stolen data to customize lures at scale. Clumsy grammar and awkward phrasing, the classic tells, are no longer enough on their own to spot malicious content.

Counter-intuitive tell: flawless grammar is now a bigger signal than poor mechanics, since it's unusual for how a real sender typically writes, especially in invoice and payment fraud impersonating brands like BOC, 3M, and FAGOR.

03 · CONTEXT CHECK

Grabbing headlines: signal vs. clickbait

AI-threat news ranges from real capability shifts to modular "attacker platform" tooling to plain clickbait. Headlines exaggerate for clicks, but the underlying capability shift is real and worth tracking past the hype.

04 · DETECTION TECHNIQUE

Detecting LLM-generated content

Grammar-based detection is close to dead: most people don't consistently use Oxford commas or format dates correctly, but an LLM usually does. From known senders, the better signal is a change in tone or mechanics, not just errors, since LLMs impersonate humans with good grammar, not a specific person's known voice.

Rule of thumb: compare a message against what you'd expect from that sender, the signature, greeting, and detail, rather than hunting for typos.

05 · FIELD NOTES

The threat landscape today

Eleven active campaigns and techniques Proofpoint is tracking right now, in the order presented.

● Social engineering ● Credential / MFA ● Malware & RMM delivery ● Financial fraud

COLLAPSE ALL

01

ClickFix Social Engineering Technique

SOCIAL ENGINEERING ▼

"We all want to be helpful"

A fake "verification" or CAPTCHA problem comes with a ready-made fix that walks the victim through Win+R → Ctrl+V → Enter, running the attacker's clipboard payload themselves. Observed lures include fake GitHub vulnerability alerts and fake "I am not a robot" pages, with campaign volume spiking past 30/month by early 2025.

02

CoGUI Phish Kit Targets Japan... and now the rest of the world

CREDENTIAL / MFA ▼

Highest-volume phishing kit in current Proofpoint data

Impersonates well-known consumer and finance brands (Amazon, PayPal, Apple, Rakuten, and others) to steal usernames, passwords, and payment data. Message volume roughly tripled between Dec 2024 and Apr 2025, from about 50M to over 150M messages.

03 **AiTM Attacks Driving MFA Modernisation**

When phishing isn't just vanilla phishing

CREDENTIAL / MFA ▼

A reverse-proxy phishing page relays the victim's login, MFA included, in real time, capturing the valid session cookie and reusing it to log in as them. Legacy push/OTP MFA is losing effectiveness against this, pushing organizations toward phishing-resistant MFA.

04 **Fake Updates**

New threat actors, and new Mac malware

MALWARE DELIVERY ▼

Fake Safari and Chrome update pages walk victims through a spoofed System Preferences dialog requesting file-update permission, a pattern long common on Windows that is now clearly targeting Mac users too.

05 **Latin American Threat Actors Are Expanding**

TA2725 dominated global malware volumes in 2024

MALWARE DELIVERY ▼

TA2725 was the top attributed threat actor in 2024 and kept rotating targets across Latin America and worldwide into 2025, switching payloads from noisy Brazilian banking trojans toward Donut Loader, ScreenConnect, and PDQConnect RMM.

06 **Remote Monitoring & Management (RMM) Tools**

Increasingly an attacker's first choice

MALWARE DELIVERY ▼

Malicious RMM use has surged since mid-2024, with **ScreenConnect** the single most popular first-stage payload among cybercriminals, dozens of campaigns weekly, alongside Fleetdeck, NetSupport, and Bluetrait.

07 **Account Compromise Leads to Credit Card Theft**

FINANCIAL FRAUD ▼

Restaurant reservation lures

A French-language campaign abuses compromised restaurant email accounts to send reservation confirmations, sometimes pre-filled with real stolen details, linking to a counterfeit payment page. The lure and landing page languages didn't match, a tell worth training users to notice.

08 **Supply Chain Compromise**

MALWARE DELIVERY ▼

Highly targeted, multistage malware delivery

A compromised email account at an Indian electronics firm was used to target five UAE aviation, satellite, and transport companies with a trade-show lure, running a multistage LNK-to-loader chain that installs the **Sosana** backdoor.

09 **Subscription Bombing & Teams IT Phishing**

SOCIAL ENGINEERING ▼

Multi-channel attacks

Actors flood a target's inbox ("subscription bombing"), then call or message on Microsoft Teams posing as IT support offering to fix it, the real goal being to talk the victim into installing an RMM tool. Combining channels makes the IT-support pretext feel more legitimate.

10 **Social Engineering via TOAD**

SOCIAL ENGINEERING ▼

Telephone-Oriented Attack Delivery

Pairs a message lure (invoices, receipts, subscriptions) with a phone number the target calls, where the actor socially engineers them into downloading RMM software. A fake Charles Schwab "asset transfer confirmation" used a non-Schwab sender and an artificially short deadline to force urgency.

11 **Unsubscribe Links: an Oldie but a Goodie**

Spot the bad link

CREDENTIAL / MFA ▼

An advance-fee investment pitch invites a reply by email or WhatsApp, but the real trap is the "unsubscribe" button, hyperlinked to a personalized credential harvester pre-filled with the victim's username and their own organization's logo.

06 · WRAP-UP

Closing summary

The session closed with an AI-generated summary of its own subject matter, a fitting note given the theme.

"The current cyber threat landscape is a rapidly evolving battlefield, characterized by increasingly sophisticated and automated attacks like ransomware, social engineering, and supply chain compromises, often fueled by geopolitical tensions. AI acts as a double-edged sword: while it empowers defenders with enhanced threat detection, response, and predictive capabilities, it also arms adversaries with tools for generating hyper-realistic phishing, adaptive malware, and scaled, automated attacks, accelerating the pace and complexity of the threats we face."

SUMMARY SLIDE, COURTESY OF AI

Unofficial personal notes on Proofpoint Cybersecurity Academy training, CLC: 2026 Certified AI Email Security Specialist, Session 1 of 3.

Next up: Sessions 2 & 3 of the AI Email Security Specialist path.